

Patient Interview Analysis: Medication & Pharmacy Management

A qualitative analysis of two exploratory interviews on medication adherence behavior and pharmacy interactions, aimed at extracting pain points, needs, behaviors, and design insights.

Executive Summary

Two interviews were conducted with two very different personas in terms of health context and age: the first is an independent adult managing chronic medications (blood pressure and cholesterol) entirely on his own, and the second is an elderly woman (65) with diabetes and hypertension who relies almost completely on her daughter. Despite the differences between the two cases, clear shared patterns emerged around missed doses, difficulty tracking medication running out, losing paper prescriptions, in addition to fundamental differences in the degree of independence and reliance on others.

The Two Personas Studied

Independent Persona 1

- Adult, working, fully self-managed
- Daily chronic medications: blood pressure + cholesterol
- Uses phone reminders and photographs prescriptions

Dependent Persona 2

- Woman, 65 years old, diabetes and hypertension
- Relies entirely on her daughter for organizing and tracking
- Faces challenges with memory, mobility, and eyesight

Pain Points

Pain Point	Persona 1	Persona 2
Missed doses	Happened before, especially on busy days or early outings	Happens when tired or after long sleep, a particular source of anxiety due to diabetes

Uncertainty about whether a dose was taken	Actual confusion happened about whether the morning dose was taken	Not explicitly mentioned, but she relies entirely on an external cue (the divided pillbox)
Running out of medication without warning	Sometimes discovered late despite monitoring the box	Does not track this herself at all; relies solely on her daughter
Losing the paper prescription	Actually happened, requiring another doctor visit	A recurring problem, solved only thanks to the daughter photographing prescriptions
Medication unavailable at the pharmacy	Takes time and effort calling and moving between pharmacies	Relies entirely on her daughter to handle it
Dependence on others	Not present; fully self-managed	A clear source of emotional distress; a feeling of losing independence
Physical limitations (vision / mobility)	Not mentioned	Difficulty reading small print, and depends on others to get to the pharmacy

Needs

- **A smart, interactive reminder system:** Both personas need a reminder that goes beyond a simple notification and actually confirms the dose was taken (an explicit request from Persona 1).
- **Early alert for medication running low:** A shared need to know remaining quantity is down to a week or less, to avoid interruption of a critical medication.
- **Digital archive for prescriptions:** A direct solution to the lost-paper problem, and explicitly requested as a desired app feature.
- **Design that accommodates older adults:** Larger font, audio alerts, and a simplified interface (explicitly requested by Persona 2).
- **A caregiver-sharing/involvement feature:** A need specific to cases dependent on another family member for tracking adherence.
- **Information on medication availability at nearby pharmacies:** Reducing time wasted calling and traveling in search of an alternative.

Behaviors

Behavior	Persona 1	Persona 2
Dose reminders	Phone reminder + keeping the box in a visible spot	A pillbox divided by day of the week, prepared by her daughter
When there's a simple question	Asks the pharmacist directly	Also asks the pharmacist first
When there's a complex issue/symptoms	Goes back to the doctor	Her daughter takes her directly to the doctor
Choosing a pharmacy	A nearby pharmacy that knows him	A nearby pharmacy she can reach on foot
When medication is unavailable	Asks about an alternative, then calls other pharmacies himself	Calls her daughter to handle it
Keeping prescriptions	Photographs them himself as a backup	Doesn't keep them; her daughter is the one who photographs them

Insights

1) Medication adherence is tied to ongoing cognitive load, not a lack of motivation.

Both personas are fully aware of the importance of their medication, but the gap occurs due to cognitive burden (remembering multiple schedules, conditions, doses) rather than negligence. This means the most suitable solution is to "offload" this burden through a reliable external tool, not merely "reminding the person of their responsibility."

2) There is a spectrum of independence levels the product must serve, not a single pattern. Persona 1 represents the "independent user" who manages everything himself, while Persona 2 represents the "dependent user" whose medication is effectively managed by a third party (caregiver). Any successful solution must support both modes: full self-management, and management-by-proxy through a family member, with dual notifications for both.

3) Running out of medication and losing the prescription are two recurring friction points independent of age or independence level. Both cases mentioned the exact same two problems in nearly identical detail (discovering medication has run out too late, and losing the paper prescription). This raises the priority of these two features (remaining-quantity tracking + prescription archiving) as a solution that "serves everyone" regardless of age segment.

4) Dependence on a caregiver carries an emotional dimension, not just a logistical one. Persona 2 expressed a wish to go back to relying on herself "like before," suggesting that losing independence in medication management touches an elderly user's sense of dignity. Any feature aimed at older adults should be designed to make the user feel empowered (e.g., a

simple confirmation the user performs themselves) and not only as a monitoring tool for the family.

5) The relationship with the pharmacist and doctor is governed by a "complexity escalation" logic for the independent user. Persona 1 clearly distinguished: simple questions (timing/drug interaction) go to the pharmacist, and questions related to a change in condition or side effects go to the doctor. Any guidance content within the app can use this same classification to direct the user on who to ask and when.

Suggested Design Recommendations

- An interactive reminder that asks for confirmation of "dose taken" rather than just a passive notification.
- A smart counter for the remaining quantity of each medication with an alert about a week before it runs out.
- A digital vault for prescriptions (photo + date + doctor) shareable directly with the pharmacist.
- A "caregiver" mode that allows linking a family member's account to track adherence and notifications.
- Accessibility settings: large font, audio alerts, and a simplified mode for older users.
- A simple in-app guide clarifying when to contact the pharmacist versus the doctor.

Analysis prepared based on two exploratory interviews (n=2) intended to surface initial hypotheses; a larger sample size is recommended before generalizing the findings.